woodwork which were contained in notably Islamic-looking six-pointed stars and surrounded by intricate arabesques. It made no difference – Ellenborough had asked for the gates, and the gates he would get.

A proclamation was duly issued by Ellenborough, addressed to the chiefs and princes of northern and western India, in which the Governor General spoke of how an insult of 800 years was finally avenged and centuries of Indian subjugation to Afghans in pre-colonial times had been reversed: thanks to the British, the gates that were once a memorial of Hindu humiliation had become instead a record of Indian superiority in arms over the nations beyond the Indus. The gates were duly paraded around India, accompanied by an imposing escort, where they were ceremoniously displayed to bewildered bystanders in an attempt to impress upon the people of India the undiminished power and benevolence of British rule. There was, however, no reaction from the Indian princes, and still less from the Hindus, neither of whom had been aware that they were missing any gates.[56] As Rawlinson observed while supervising the removal of the beautiful Seljuk woodwork: the gates could hardly be restored because they were not from Somnath; the temple had been in ruins for a thousand years; and the Hindus were anyway totally indifferent to the whole farce.[57]

Nor were the Afghans particularly upset to see the gates go. According to Rawlinson, the custodian of the shrine merely shrugged his shoulders and said: 'Of what use can these old timbers be to you?'[58] Mirza 'Ata was more cutting: 'Ellenborough ordered the gates to be sent to India, where they could be used to publicize the re-conquest of Khorasan and justify the huge expense of operations in a country which produced so little revenue. As the saying goes, real power does not need tawdry propaganda! A more lasting monument until today is the quantity of rotting corpses of the English troops that still block the highways and byways of Khorasan.'[59]

Throughout July there were several attempts at negotiating an exchange of prisoners. First Mackenzie then Lawrence was despatched to Jalalabad to try to make a deal with Pollock; but in the end the talks came to nothing, and both men honourably returned to their captivity having given Akbar Khan their word that they would do so.

Pottinger in particular wrote a letter cautioning Pollock against making a deal which freed all the British officers and their women while leaving large